Praise to the One Who Transcends the World

Lokātītastava · Toh 1120 · Derge Tengyur
འཇིག་རྟེན་ལས་འདས་པར་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise to the One Who Transcends the World, known in Sanskrit as the Lokātītastava and in Tibetan as Jikten Lé Dépar Töpa, is a hymn in verse attributed to the master Nāgārjuna and traditionally counted among his collected praises of the Buddha. Addressing the Buddha as one who has gone beyond the world yet labors tirelessly for beings out of compassion, it praises his teaching through a series of Middle Way arguments: that the aggregates are like illusions and dreams, that agent and action, knower and known, and characteristic and characterized are established only in mutual dependence, that nothing arises from itself, from another, from both, or without a cause, and that whatever arises dependently is empty. It recalls that the Buddha taught emptiness as a nectar for ending all conceptions and censured those who cling even to it, and it closes by dedicating the merit of the praise to freeing all beings from the bondage of signs. Its colophon names the Indian scholar Kṛṣṇa Paṇḍita and the Tibetan translator Tsultrim Gyalwa as its translators and editors, and it is Toh 1120 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of hymns of praise, or stotra.

In the language of India: lokātītastavaṃ
In the language of Tibet: Praise to the One Who Transcends the World

Homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī.

You who know the gnosis of isolation,
Transcender of the world, I pay homage and bow to you,
You who, for the benefit of beings,
Have long been wearied by compassion.

You hold that there is no sentient being
Apart from the mere aggregates;
Yet even for wretched beings, with supreme devotion,
You yourself, Great Sage, set to work.

Wise One, those aggregates as well
You have taught to the wise
To be just like an illusion, a mirage,
A city of gandharvas, or a dream.

Since whatever arises from causes
Does not exist without them,
Why would one not clearly hold
That they are just like reflections?

Since the elements are not grasped by the eye,
How could what is made of them belong to the eye?
Thoroughly refuting that form is grasped,
Thus have you spoken of form itself.

Since without something to be felt it does not exist,
And since feeling itself is without self,
You hold that feeling too
Does not exist by its intrinsic nature.

Were name and object not different,
The mouth itself would be burned by fire;
And if they were different, there would be no understanding:
So you, who speak the truth, have taught.

An independent agent, and action too,
You have taught in conventional terms;
But you hold that they are established
As mutually dependent.

There is no agent, nor any experiencer;
Merit and its opposite arise dependently;
Though born in dependence, they are unborn:
So you, Lord of Speech, have declared.

Without knowing, there is nothing knowable;
Without that, there is no consciousness either;
Therefore you have said that knowing and the knowable
Have no entity of their own.

If characteristic and characterized were other,
The characterized would be without characteristic;
And if they are not different, they do not exist either:
This you have taught with perfect clarity.

Free of characteristic and characterized,
Wholly beyond expression in words,
Through your very eye of gnosis

You have brought these beings to peace.

An existent thing does not arise,
Nor a nonexistent, nor one both existent and nonexistent;
Not from itself, not from another,
Not from both: how then is there arising?

It would be reasonable for the existent to endure,
And so it would not come to perish;
Since it is reasonable that the nonexistent does not endure,
It does not come to perish.

To begin with, it is not reasonable that a result
Should arise from a cause that has ceased,
Nor from one that has not ceased; you yourself
Hold that arising is like a dream.

Results that arise from causes,
Whether ceased or not ceased,
Arise just as an illusion arises;
And you have said that all things are likewise.

Therefore you have said that these beings,
Arising from imputation,
Even as they arise as what is to be fully known,
Are unborn and unceasing.

For the permanent there is no saṃsāra,
And for the impermanent there is no saṃsāra either;
You, the best of those who know reality,
Have said that saṃsāra is like a dream.

That suffering is made by itself,
Made by another, made by both,
Or without cause, the logicians hold;
You have said that it arises in dependence.

Whatever arises in dependence and relation,
That very thing you hold to be empty;
"No entity exists independently":
So declares your unequaled lion's roar.

When you teach the nectar of emptiness
So that all conceptions may be abandoned,
Whoever clings to it
You strongly censure.

Inert, of a dependent nature, emptiness itself,
Arising from conditions like an illusion:
Protector, thus have you made yourself familiar
With the absence of entity in all phenomena.

You did not bring anything at all into being,
Nor was anything at all stopped;
As it was before, so it is after:
Suchness is what you realized.

Without entering the meditation
Taught by the noble ones, could this signlessness
Ever become known to consciousness?

Because you have said that without entering
Into signlessness there is no liberation,
Therefore you taught that very thing
Without exception throughout the Great Vehicle.

From praising you, the vessel of praise,
Whatever merit I have gained,
By it may all beings without exception
Be freed from the bondage of signs.

This completes the Praise to the One Who Transcends the World, composed by the noble master Nāgārjuna. It was translated, revised, and finalized by the Indian preceptor Kṛṣṇa Paṇḍita and the translator Tsultrim Gyalwa.

Translator's Notes

• In the eighth verse, krub is read as grub, "established," the evident reading.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human

translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.